

COMMITTEE
MEMBERS'
PAPERS
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Lodge System of
Masonic
Education
Utah, 1961

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THE LODGE SYSTEM OF MASONIC EDUCATION

Prepared by
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A Short History of Freemasonry

Meeting No. 1

Subject No. 1

Tonight, I shall tell you a little about the story of Freemasonry the better to enable you to understand the three steps of initiation which lie before you.

Men of all ages and of all lands have had secret societies, have used ceremonies of initiation, employed symbols, emblems and means of recognition. When Freemasonry came into existence, nobody knows how many centuries ago, it inherited from such societies many of its rites and a number of its symbols. During your initiation ceremonies you will encounter them.

The oldest existing written record of our Craft is a manuscript written about 1390. This document itself shows that Freemasonry was, even then, very old.

At the time this document was written all Masons were Operative - that is, they were workers engaged in the construction of buildings. A Master Mason or Freemason was a man who had served his apprenticeship and was no longer a bondman but freed as a consequence of his having served his time and become a Master of his Craft. Such men designed, supervised and erected cathedrals and other marvelous Gothic edifices of Europe. Their work was difficult, called for a high degree of skill and genius, required a complete knowledge of mechanics and geometry. They were the great artisans of the Middle Ages.

Training men for such work required a long period of severe discipline. Boys, sound in body and mind and of good reputation, were selected at the age of ten or twelve and apprenticed to some Master Mason for about seven years. This Master Mason became the boy's tutor, monitor, guide, and taught him all the theories and practices of the Craft. At the end of his apprenticeship the youth was required to

submit to exacting tests of his proficiency before being accepted by the Craft as a Master Mason.

When Masons congregated in readiness to commence the construction of an edifice, they organized a Lodge which met in a temporary building. Such a Lodge was governed by a Worshipful Master assisted by Wardens, divided its membership into grades, admitted members by initiation and was, in short, what a Masonic Lodge is to-day.

The beginner learning the builder's trade was called an Apprentice. After he had served sufficient time to give evidence of his fitness, he was entered on the Lodge's books, after which he was called an Entered Apprentice. Upon completion of his apprenticeship he was called into open Lodge, his conduct reported, and he was set to prove his skill by producing his "Master's Piece." If he passed his test satisfactorily he became a full member of the Craft, with all of its duties, rights and privileges and was called a "Fellow of the Craft"; in the sense that he had mastered the duties, rules, practices secrets and tools of his trade he was called; Master Mason.

Such was the Fraternity in its Operative period; and as such it flourished for generations.

Then came a change: The Reformation came, and the Gothic style of architecture began to die out; social conditions changed; laws were changed. These and many other factors brought about a decline in the Craft. During the 16th and 17th Centuries Freemasons became few in number. Their numbers then increased through admission into their ranks of gentlemen - men not interested in building construction - who were attracted by their morality, and perhaps out of curiosity, or for social reasons. And because they were thus accepted, they were called "Accepted Masons." Their number increased until, in the early part of the 18th century, they outnumbered the Operatives in number and influence.

As a result of this, four or more "Old Lodges" of London and Westminster met and organized the first Grand Lodge. Within a few years the Craft had transformed itself from an Operative Body into a

Speculative Fraternity (by Speculative is meant Masonry in a moral or symbolical sense); reorganized the old two degrees into the three degrees of Entered Apprentice, Fellowcraft and Master Mason, collected the old manuscripts, produced the First Book of Constitutions and chartered Lodges in many countries including our own.

In 1751 a second Grand Lodge was organized in England and, later on, the two Grand Lodges consolidated and organized the United Grand Lodge.

Early American Lodges, organized about 1730, were placed under the charge of Provincial Grand Lodges which were ruled by Provincial Grand Masters appointed by Grand Lodges in England, Scotland or Ireland.

As a result of the American Revolution, American Grand Lodges became sovereign and independent. As the years passed a Grand Lodge has been organized in each State and is sovereign within its territorial limits. Today we have in the United States 49 Grand Lodges (one being in the District of Columbia) about 16,000 Lodges and more than 4,000,000 members.

Operative Masons erected buildings. We as Masons, try to build character, manhood. Their tools we have transformed into emblems of moral and spiritual laws and forces; their rituals we employ in the initiation of our candidates and as you enter into it you will discover it a power in your life to ennoble and inspire.

The Duties and Privileges of Lodge Membership

Meeting No. 1

Subject No. 2

In petitioning for the Three Degrees of Masonry your desire was to become a member of a Lodge. When the members of this Lodge elected you to receive the Degrees it was with the understanding that you would ultimately become a member of this or some other Lodge. Therefore, I have been delegated to speak to you on the duties and privileges of Lodge membership. Of course, there is much that cannot at this time be explained to you but there is much that you should understand at this stage of your Journey.

You will become a member of a Lodge by receiving the Three Degrees, by proving your proficiency in each of them and by signing the By-Laws. The relationship is contractual-that is, you bind yourself to perform certain duties and the Lodge binds itself to protect you in certain rights and privileges.

One of the first of your duties will be loyalty to the Fraternity, faithfulness to your superior officers and obedience to the laws and the Landmarks.

It will be your duty to hold membership in some Lodge, and if any Mason remains unaffiliated with a Lodge for six months, he is denied desirable rights and privileges.

It will be your duty to pay your dues promptly; and, as your conscience shall guide and your means permit, to lend a helping hand to a Brother Mason in sickness or distress.

If you are present at a regular meeting of the Lodge when a ballot is held on a petition for initiation or affiliation, you must vote-it is required by Masonic law.

It will be your duty to attend meetings of your Lodge, to join in its deliberations, to have a voice in its decisions and to assist in

discharging its responsibilities. You will not be expected to attend, however, if it works a hardship on yourself or your family.

If the Worshipful Master, acting in accordance with Constitutional provisions, issues a summons to you to attend a meeting of the Lodge for some special purpose or to discharge some Masonic duty, it will be your duty to obey the summons if within the scope of your reasonable ability to do so.

Other duties will be made dear to you as you progress. Lodge membership is not a mere gesture of honor nor an idle privilege, nor does it mean that a member has the privilege of evading his responsibilities by shifting his duties to more willing shoulders- the “let George do it” kind. The Mystic Tie by which he is bound to his fellows has in it a strand of steel held fast by stringent laws, to ignore which is to incur discipline.

I shall now explain some of the rights and privileges which are made equally secure by the Fraternity.

If you move away from the jurisdiction of your Lodge you will have the right to transfer your membership provided you are in good standing in the first Lodge and your petition is favorably acted upon in the second Lodge.

A member of a Lodge is eligible to any office except that of Master. He is eligible to the office of Master if he has been previously installed as a Warden or Master.

You will have the right to visit any Lodge anywhere, provided the Worshipful Master is willing to admit you after you have been vouched for or examined.

As a Master Mason in good standing you will have the right to join in public processions, a privilege carefully guarded by our laws, since, to join in such is public identification with the Fraternity.

In case of death you will be entitled to Masonic burial unless your conduct in life reflected discreditably upon the Fraternity.

Besides, it means that your family may to a certain extent be brought within the care of a Lodge at a time, perhaps, when friendly counsel is needed.

If you, unfortunately, expose yourself to formal discipline, you will have the right of hearing, of counsel, of appearing in your own defense, of submitting evidence, of trial by Masons and, if found guilty, of making appeal to Grand Lodge.

The Lodge and the Grand Lodge give many services and extend many opportunities for entertainment and educational advantages. As a Master Mason you will have the privilege of enjoying these equally with all others.

When among strangers you will have certain modes of recognition by which to prove yourself to another Master Mason.

You are not to understand that these duties, rights and privileges of Masonic membership are exhaustive. The above are but a few of them: but we trust that, with the light which this has given, you will go forward with a livelier understanding of what Masonry will mean to you and of what, we trust, you may mean to Masonry.

The Machinery and Organization of a Lodge

Meeting No. 1

Subject No. 3

You have been elected to receive the Degrees of Masonry. Before you become a member, you will appear three times in the Lodge to receive the Degrees. Since you will thus come into contact with the Lodge and later become a member, it will be of assistance to you to learn how a Lodge is organized and what its machinery is. Much about a Lodge is secret, to be learned only through initiation; what is now told you is written in the Code of Laws of our Grand Lodge.

A Lodge is an organization of seven or more Master Masons empowered by a Grand Lodge to confer the Three Degrees of Masonry and to do such work and to carry on such activities as appertain thereto.

Authority is conferred by a Charter issued by a Grand Lodge. you will later be shown the Charter of our own Lodge. It was issued to us by the Grand Lodge of Free and Accepted Masons of Utah.

A Lodge can retain its Charter only as it obeys the laws of the Grand Lodge and works according to the traditions, ancient usages and customs of the Masonic Fraternity.

Each Lodge can make Masons only of such elected petitioners as live within its jurisdiction. If there be only one Lodge in a city, all persons residing nearer to it by an air line than to any other Lodge must petition it for the Degrees; If there be more than one Lodge, they have concurrent jurisdiction-that is, a petitioner may make his choice among them.

A Lodge is governed by the Grand Lodge according to laws laid down in the Grand Lodge Code of Laws. Those laws define the province within which a Lodge governs itself. Certain of the laws and

rules of its self-government are embodied in its By-Laws, a copy of which you will be required to sign when you become a member.

Each Lodge in this Jurisdiction has at least ten officers, five of whom are chosen by ballot. These are the Worshipful Master, Senior Warden, Junior Warden, Secretary and Treasurer. They are elected at the first regular meeting in December.

The primary executive power of the Lodge is vested in the office of Worshipful Master.

The Senior Warden is the second ranking officer. If the Worshipful Master be absent, the Senior Warden presides in his place. If, through absence or inability the office of Worshipful Master becomes vacant, the Senior Warden succeeds to all his prerogatives and duties for all purposes except such as pertain to the installation of officers. The Senior Warden has other duties which you will learn later.

Next in rank is the Junior Warden who governs the Lodge in the absence or inability of the Worshipful Master and Senior Warden.

Neither a Master nor Warden may resign his office.

The Secretary of the Lodge keeps its minutes, receives all money due the Lodge and pays it to the Treasurer, prepares reports to Grand Lodge, conducts its correspondence, files petitions, etc.

The Treasurer receives Lodge money from the Secretary, keeps a true account of it and pays it out by order of the Lodge upon warrants certified by the Master and Secretary.

The Tiler guards the outer door to see that no one enters the Lodge except those entitled to do so.

In addition to its officers a Lodge has various standing and special committees.

The meetings of the Lodge are of two kinds, regular and special. Regular meetings are held on dates set by the By-Laws. Special meetings are called by the Worshipful Master.

There are three Degrees in Masonry. These are conferred only at meetings of the Lodge, either regular or special. An Entered Apprentice may sit in a Lodge only when it is working on that Degree; a Fellowcraft, only when in the Fellowcraft or Entered Apprentice Degrees. A member of the Lodge has the right to sit in it and to vote in any meeting. Visitors may sit in it only by consent of the Worshipful Master.

A man cannot petition for the Degrees unless he has resided in the State for twelve months and in the jurisdiction of the Lodge at least six months. There are certain exceptions to this rule which you will learn later.

The petitioner must sign his full name to his petition and satisfactorily answer a list of questions. His petition must also be signed by two members of the Lodge he petitions.

The Lodge receives his petition at a regular meeting, after which it is referred to an investigating committee of three members who return a report in writing. The Lodge must ballot on the petition at a regular meeting. To be elected the petitioner must receive an unanimously favorable ballot. The one ballot elects for all three degrees.

Before receiving the Degrees, a petitioner must pay an initiation fee fixed in the Lodge By-Laws. When he becomes a member, he must pay annual dues, also fixed in the By-Laws. These fees and dues comprise the principal sources of income of a Lodge. The Lodge may also receive income from endowments and other similar sources. For each candidate initiated the Lodge must pay a fee to Grand Lodge; and for each member it must also pay annual dues.

In brief outline and to the extent to which you can now understand it, such is the machinery and form of organization of a Masonic Lodge. It conveys only a hint of the rich life and manifold activities of a Lodge as a member knows them. In due course you will enjoy privileges of membership in this Lodge and find it exceeds all your expectations.

The Landmarks

Meeting No. 1

Subject No. 4.

Freemasonry has honored the term "Landmarks" as a name for one of the most important of its basic laws, namely, that there are in the Craft certain principles, practices, traditions, usages or laws which cannot be changed by any Mason, Lodge or Grand Lodge. It is this we mean when we speak of "The Ancient Landmarks", a phrase you will hear often during your Masonic career. Let us see if we can explain that phrase, at least in its larger meaning.

Freemasonry has an identity, a character of its own. Some things in it can be abolished, changed or modified, without destroying that identity-that is, after the change is made Freemasonry continues to be what it was before. But there are other changes which, if they were made, would destroy Freemasonry itself-that is, it would cease to have its own identity and would become something else.

Landmarks signify that which in Masonry is essential to its identity.

Let me call your attention briefly to a few examples which will make the meaning clear- remembering that these are by no means the complete list.

Many of the things in Masonry are kept secret from the outside world. This secrecy is not a theatrical pose but is so essential to the very nature of the Craft that we could not conceive of Masonry without it. Gone would be the ritual, initiation, the obligations, the modes of recognition and all that home-like privacy that makes Lodge--life delightful. Secrecy, therefore, has the power of a Landmark.

Ever since it began, Masonry has admitted adult men only to membership. A boy under age could not be held accountable to his obligations; and if women were admitted it would call for such a recasting of our system from top to bottom that little of it would remain standing.

Again, each petitioner is required to possess certain qualifications, must be sound of limb, well recommended, of good character, free born, of mature age. If these qualifications were removed, men of every sort would be admitted, men not physically, mentally or morally capable of living the Masonic life; the result would be no Masonry to live.

But it is not sufficient for a petitioner to be well qualified in order to gain admittance; he must also pass through the rites of initiation. This also has been an integral part of our Fraternity from the very beginning and it is so vital to it that the whole system presupposes it throughout.

The Ritual, with its assemblage of symbols, emblems and allegories, is yet another character belonging to the nature of Masonry.

Another equally essential factor is the secret, unanimous ballot. Since it is the principal purpose of the Craft to bring men together into brotherly relation, it is necessary that such candidates as are admitted shall not disturb harmony among its members.

My last example: Belief in God, with the Altar at the center of the Lodge and having the Holy Bible open upon it; hope of immortality, belief in prayer--here is the religious basis of Freemasonry--and I use the word basis literally. If this spiritual life were destroyed, our Fraternity would degenerate into a mere social club---something diametrically opposed to what it is.

I have given you this explanation of the principle of the Landmarks through a series of examples for one purpose. When I state that purpose I shall have concluded.

You are not yet a Mason. If you have the good fortune to become a member of a Lodge and if, thereafter, you progress in Masonic knowledge and experience as we trust you may, then you will win an understanding of this subject in a more technical manner and you will have the advantage of seeing it from the inside instead of from the outside. But at your present stage the subject is of the utmost

importance to you, and for this reason: it makes plain to you that Freemasonry is clearly conscious of what belongs to its own proper nature; against every possible influence it guards and cherishes that nature continually; the petitioner who comes into its membership must accept it as he finds it or not at all. There is no way to change Masonry to suit the tastes, foibles, prejudices or opinions of the candidate; it is the candidate who must change himself to conform to Masonry. To become a Mason, therefore, you must stand ready with all sincerity to give whole-hearted assent to its teachings and principles, obedience to its laws and regulations and observance to its Ancient Landmarks.

Freemasonry's Attitude to Politics and Religion

Meeting No. 1

Subject No. 5

You have already learned that in Masonry there are certain basic rules and principles called Landmarks. These Landmarks are an expression of that which belongs to Masonry's identity; if they were cancelled out Masonry would cease to be Masonry.

One of the most important of all those Landmarks is that which forbids us to participate, AS MASONS, in any form of religious or political sectarianism. We must not discuss such matters in any of our assemblies; and we cannot take any kind of public action with regard to them in the name of the Craft. A candidate must acknowledge a belief in God, a hope for immortality and reverence the Holy Bible as a rule and guide for his life. The doctrinal interpretation he may place on this belief must, however, be left entirely to him. So also, must he pledge himself to good citizenship but his choice of a political party through which he works for the realization of his ideal of citizenship, must be left entirely to him.

It is noteworthy that nothing is more likely to divide and alienate men than religious and political sectarianism. For this reason, sectarianism is prohibited because the needs and the welfare of Brotherhood demand it.

During its whole history the Fraternity has been subject to attacks from without. In our own country a hundred years ago a coalition of certain churches with a national political party undertook to stamp Masonry out of existence. Two or three of the great churches of the world still maintain that same attitude toward it. And only a few years ago several great governments have sought to outlaw it by governmental action. In all probability our Craft always will have such enemies to deal with, as does every other organization.

Our attitude toward such attacks is to ignore them. We do not fight back. We take the position that if some man, or group of men, disagrees with the teachings of Freemasonry, that is his own private affair and does not concern us. We do nothing to invite or warrant such attacks, therefore, they are no affair of ours.

Tolerance has always been one of the fundamental principles of our Fraternity. By it we DO NOT mean that one belief is as true as another, or as valuable as another; we do not advocate a general indifference to all beliefs. Tolerance encourages each man to think for himself. Tolerance means what the word implies: To put up with the religious beliefs of other men and respect them for the same reason that we like to have our own beliefs respected and without discussion or argument.

Freemasonry is dedicated to and devoted to Brotherhood. But this Brotherhood rests on a basis of religion. Every Mason believes in God. The Bible must be open on every Lodge Altar. Before engaging in any important undertaking, a Mason seeks aid and guidance through prayer. This is religion but is not a religion. It is faith but is not a faith confined to any one creed. It is worship but is not a worship chained to any one altar. In the words of the "First Book of Constitutions" it is the religion "in which all good men agree." It is the ground which underlies all religions, all churches, all creeds, and sects.

Politics means the discussion and determination of matters of public policy. Each question of national policy is, therefore, of politics, consequently, matters of politics are of the utmost importance and concern to any nation. Every citizen, if he be a good citizen, will bring to bear on such questions his best judgment and will do whatever his duty demands toward putting into effect such policies as are determined on.

This is good citizenship and Masonry demands of every member that he be a good citizen. Just as we saw that the religion of Masonry is that common ground which underlies all religious parties, so is this good citizenship the common ground under all political parties. A Mason may adhere to this political party or to that, may hold one

opinion or another about the tariff; but whatever be his party or his opinion, he must be a good citizen- law--abiding, faithful to the nation, loyal to the civil powers.

To sum up:

As a Mason you will never introduce into the Craft any controversial sectarian question; you will pay no heed to those from without who may attack the Fraternity; you will adhere to that religion in which all good men agree, and in your life as a member of the State you will be loyal to the demands of good citizenship.

